

Fitz John Porter. Most of the retreating Army of the Potomac concentrated in a formidable defensive position on Malvern Hill. Flanked by ravines, it could only be assaulted from the front by troops advancing up a slope and across an open plain. The Union artillery unlimbered its cannons and waited for the enemy to show.

Lee guessed that the Union soldiers were demoralized and would crack if put under pressure. He devised a plan for his artillery to open holes in the Union line for his infantry to exploit. But everything went wrong. The Confederate guns could not be moved forward in sufficient strength and fared poorly in the artillery duel. Next, Lee's infantry assaults began piecemeal as men stormed forward singly and were shot down by shrapnel, canister, and grapeshot. Those few units that reached the Union lines were driven back by counterattacks. The following day, McClellan again ordered a Union withdrawal, but Lee did not pursue and the fighting ended.